



An abstract graphic design on the left side of the slide. It features several overlapping geometric shapes in bright yellow and orange against a dark blue background. The shapes include a large, rounded, U-like form at the top, a smaller rounded rectangle in the middle, and another large, angular shape at the bottom. The design is modern and minimalist.

Esports Visualized

Esports Visualized is a project that focuses on how graphic design takes shape in the context of the Esports community. This project highlights a few different fields of graphic design and focuses on how they are relevant and uniquely used in the context of Esports. These are done in the form of case studies. For these case studies I did extensive research into these disciplines when being used in the Esports scene. In the case studies themselves I discuss the aspect of design and how it differs when applied to Esports but take it one step further and apply it myself to give a visual demonstration of what is discussed in the case study. These were all real and applied designs made and used for a purpose in order to give an accurate depiction of what it is like to design for Esports and the unique challenges that come with it.

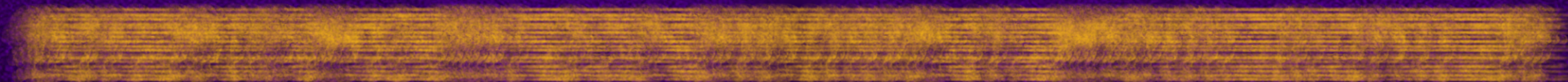
Preface

All of my final designs and work can be found on the Esports Visualized website! On this site is all of the individual fully written case studies with all of the real work that I produced through this thesis project..



esports-visualized.netlify.app/

BEFORE THESIS



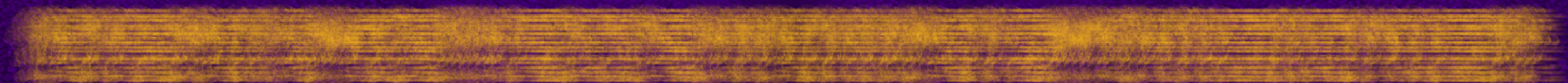
Pre-Thesis Work

Even before beginning on my thesis, I had always been very active in the various Esports scenes at New Paltz. I was both an active competitor in several titles as well as a graphic designer in the space. In specific I mainly worked as the lead graphic designer for New Paltz Smash Club and as an intern designer for SUNY/ECAC Esports.

Having been designing for Esports for a while now this project was about taking all of that knowledge I gained in the industry and distilling it into a more digestible and visually interesting format.



THESIS 1 RESEARCH



Initial Research

For my initial research process I looked at other organizations and popular media in Esports and fully dissected what techniques were being used and why. For example, I had plans to do branding similar to and Esports Team or "Org". In order to accomplish this I looked at popular Orgs that fit my vision for the project. What I found out was there was heavy use of bright, monochromatic color schemes and minimalist logos, often with heavy symbolism, that could be fit easily into any in-game or out-of-game branding. While plans did shift over time into a more distinct visual style, most of what I learned I still carried over into my new vision as the project went on.



Visual Research

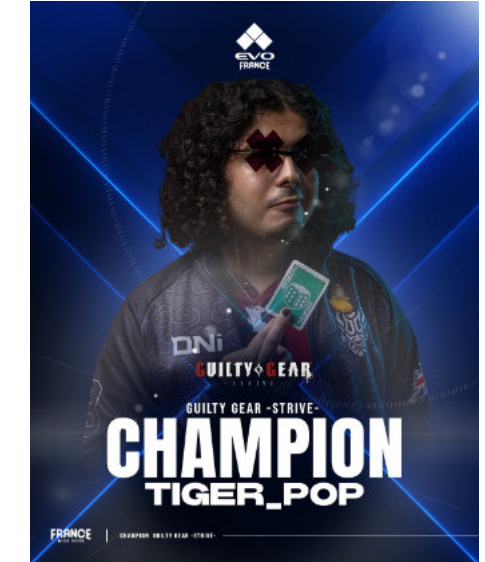
For additional research I did more focused explorations on a few different organizations that focus on one individual design field that I was interested in incorporating.



"Made by Aether Studios in October of 2024, Rivals of Aether 2 is a competitive fighting game with a unique design style. The reason I bring this up is for a different angle of legitimacy, as this game is fighting to be considered a legitimate competitive game in the fighting game community. Due to its smaller size and much smaller studio, only a few people, compared to most games in the scene it inevitably has to work a lot harder to get that same legitimacy as most other games. I'm still unsure if I will directly tackle the game development side of legitimacy in Esports but it is certainly something I will mention and this serves as a great example for that topic. You may ask why this game and this studio though? Well the studio has released a public presskit for many of the game assets and branding assets which really allows me to get a good look at their design philosophy overall. I also bring this studio up as they are the ones I will most likely be able to interview for my thesis so I can get direct anecdotes from them on how they view their own legitimacy in the esports space. You can find the website for the game here: <https://rivals2.com/presskit>"



"UAlbany has one of the largest esports scenes in the SUNY system and has a strong design style to show for it. This branding is the main standard I like to use for collegiate Esports branding which I will be touching on during my thesis as many colleges need to put up a fight for their Esports scenes to be legitimized in any way. I won't be directly replicating the idea of a collegiately branded Esports logo but it will certainly be helping me create a final product for an Esports logo in general. They also serve as a good example for designing for an Esports space. I'm not sure how much I will actually touch on this topic as my thesis isn't going to be very interior design focused but it will be nice to have. I also bring up UAlbany because I am slated to have an interview with their director about their legitimacy and how Esports has operated within their school system."



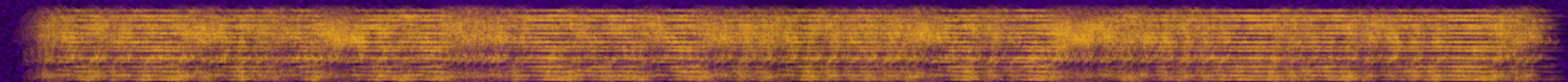
"EVO is an bi-annual event series held in the fighting game community since 1996 at locations all across the world. Being the leading event in the scene it has already had its legitimacy proven to people even outside of the Esports space. Being such a massive event as well it has had its branding refined and perfected over the course of a few decades now and has certainly stood the test of time. It touches on another crucial aspect of legitimacy in Esports, event legitimacy. For the Esports scene to run it obviously needs events to be held, and those events themselves need to be legitimate for players of a high level of talent to go to them. In the sense of my thesis I obviously won't be starting with this same level of legitimacy, so I will be using EVO as an example of great event branding and working from there to potentially establish my own event as a part of my thesis. You can see more on EVO at their website: <https://evo.gg>"

PechaKucha Presentation

My PechaKucha project presentation was a big turning point for my project. This is where I was able to solidify the idea that I wanted to make three distinct case studies in order to showcase what Esports design has to offer. It was also a big turning point in getting me more comfortable openly and confidently discussing my thesis. In terms of visual style I developed the use of purple as a good background color and was the first use of the sketchy & detailed background texture.

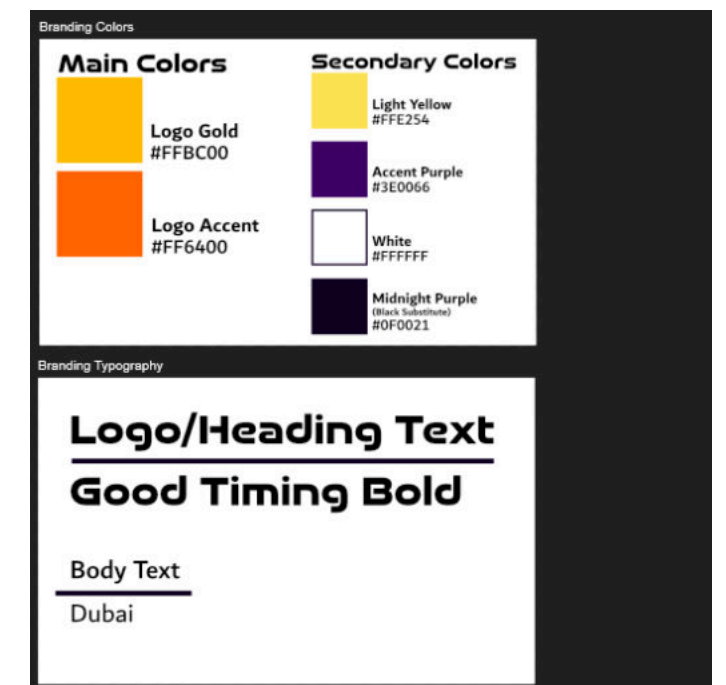
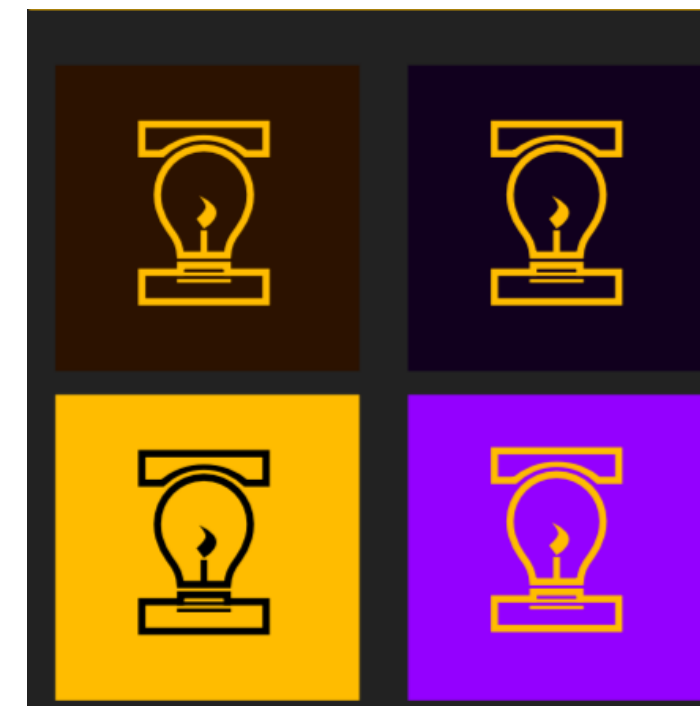
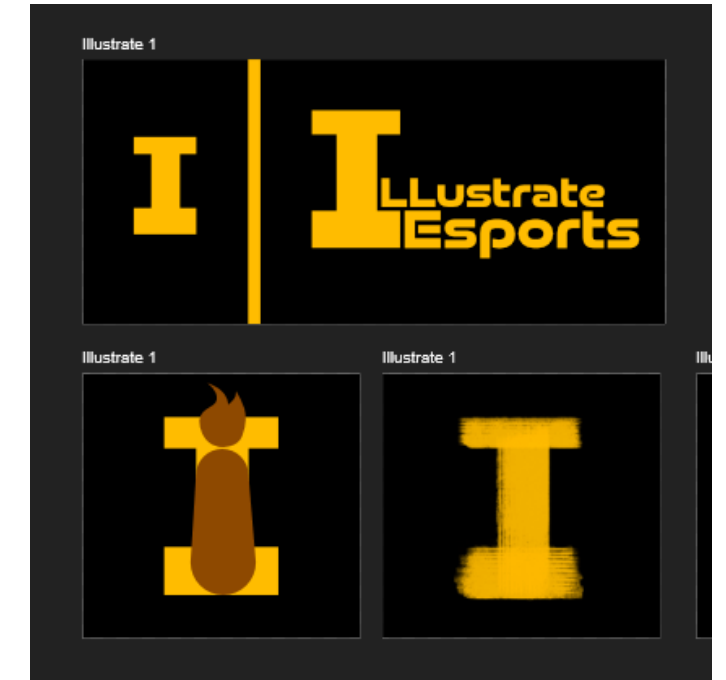
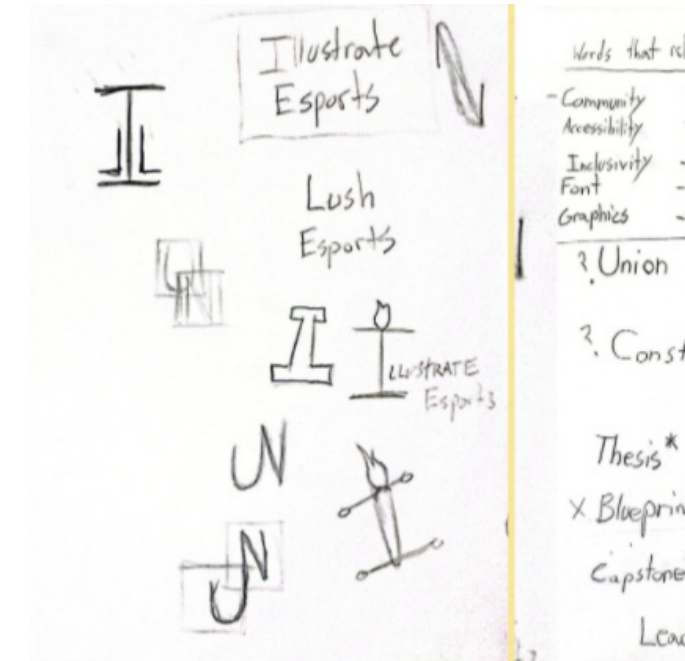


THESIS 2 PROCESS



Branding Brainstorming

The first thing on my priority list going into thesis two was to establish a branding for the project that I could base subsequent material and, most importantly, the website around. You can see here my initial sketches for the project's branding. My initial title for the project was "Illustrate Esports" and I was going for a more "Esports Organization" look. You can see the establishment here of yellow being the main color for the project, this is something I did to stand out from other Esports organizations as not many used yellow, which made it more apparent that this was a creatively-focused Esports project.



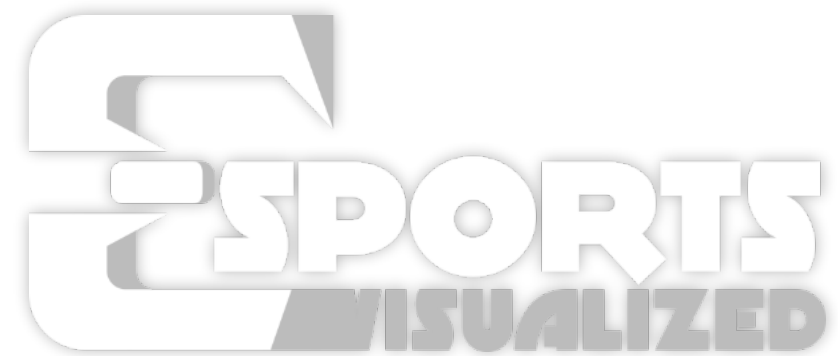
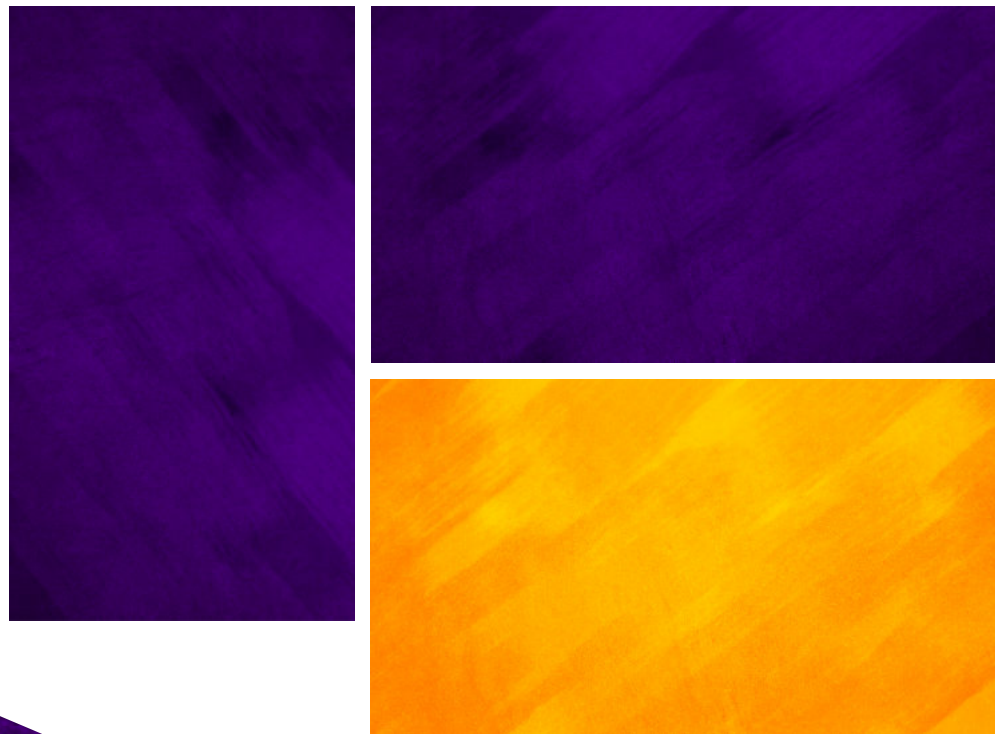
From here I developed out my first full concept for Illustrate Esports! I aimed to mimic traditional Esports Org branding in this logo while also managing to make it work for people that are coming into this for the first time. Turns out though that this initial branding, while a good start, was failing to communicate as "Esports" to people outside the scene while also not being too stand out to existing fans of Esports to necessarily matter. So it was back to brainstorming...



From here I took what I recieved positive feedback on. That being the colors, sketchy textures and letter symbolism on the letters. I instead decided to focus on the "E" in Esports as it is the central word related to my project. I also added mouse symbolism in the negative space which relates more to Esports than the brush symbolism from before. I essentially focused on adapting the original concept to be more iconic and recognizable.

Final Outcomes

And this what I ended with for my Final Branding! Included in this as well is black and white variations on the logo for multiple purposes as well as two variations on the background texture for widespread use in the project's website and advertisement. It strikes a good balance of following traditional Esports branding styles while also being recognizable and iconic to people just seeing what Esports is for the first time.

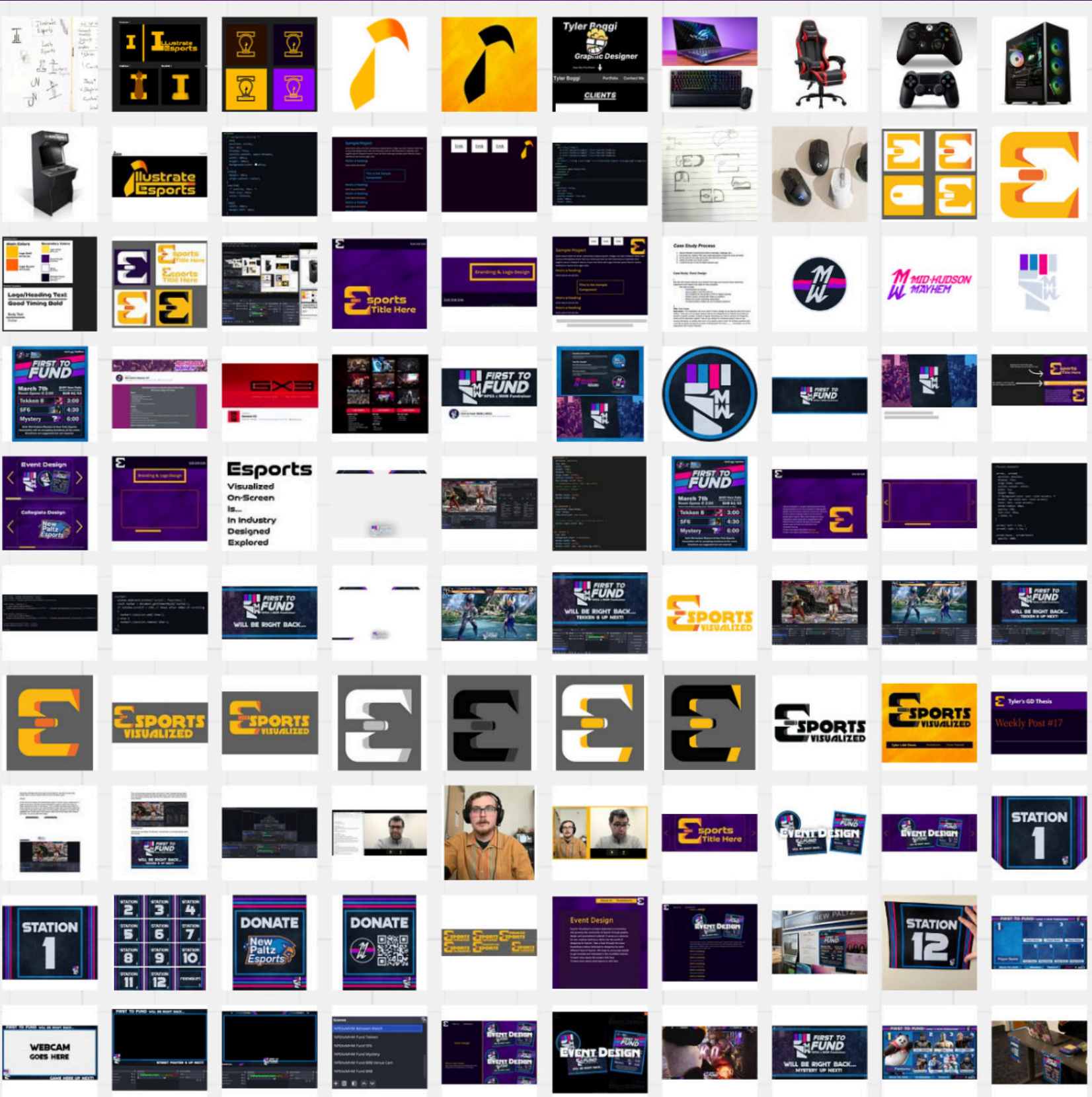


Midterm Review

A big part of getting to my final branding outcomes was the Midterm Review, which happened around the same time of me starting to reach close to final designs for my branding. I used this review to present both my branding and website progress at the time as those were the things I was actively working on.

From the review I recieved very positive feedback on my branding which had me feel much more confident about the shift in direction. I got some small tips about smaller parts of the branding which I adjusted accordingly as well.

I was also given good feedback on my website to shift towards a more artistic style on the main pages of the site in order to really show off my branding and style while actually dialing back on the case study pages so they had more room to let the works I made breathe and make the documentation more readable. Aside from that I got more positive reassurance, helping me feel more confident in the direction I was heading which I will touch on more in the Obstacles section.



My GD Blog

For my GD Thesis blog it actually helped me on a different level than just documentation of my process. I was able to use the blog to test out my own branding and see how it would work in the context of a website. Since my main deliverable was a website I customized my entire blog to fit the branding of the website and it allowed me to see what worked and what didnt work.

For example while I do like the bold yellow and black on the blog I felt that it really wouldn't fit the website so, I was able to find that out without going through the work of implementing it on the site. This saved me time to work on what was be the main bulk of my project, the case studies.



Case Study 1 - Event Design

For the main part of this project I covered three case studies on how Esports design looks in three different fields. This was all documented on the Esports Visualized website. This first case study was on Event Design, I researched the organization that we were working with as well as fist-related symbolism as I knew thats what I wanted the event to look like. For my final outcomes I made branding, advertising, streaming material, and more!

In-Progress



Final Outcomes





start.gg/NpMhm

FIRST TO FUND

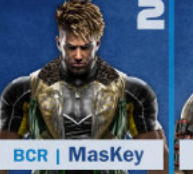
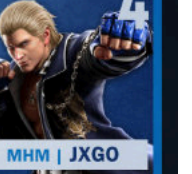
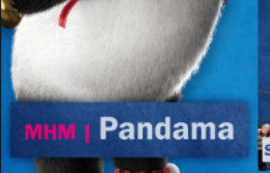
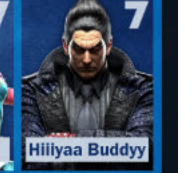
March 7th
Room Opens @ 2:00

SUNY New Paltz
Student Union Building
SUB 62/63

Tekken 8		3:00
SF6		4:30
Mystery		6:00

Both Mid-Hudson Mayhem & New Paltz Esports Association will be accepting donations at the event. Donations are suggested but not required.

FIRST TO FUND: NPEA X MHM FUNDRAISER

1	2	3	4
 MHM Pandama	 BCR MasKey	 Xeno	 MHM JXGO
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March 7th, 2026 18 Attendees Tekken 8



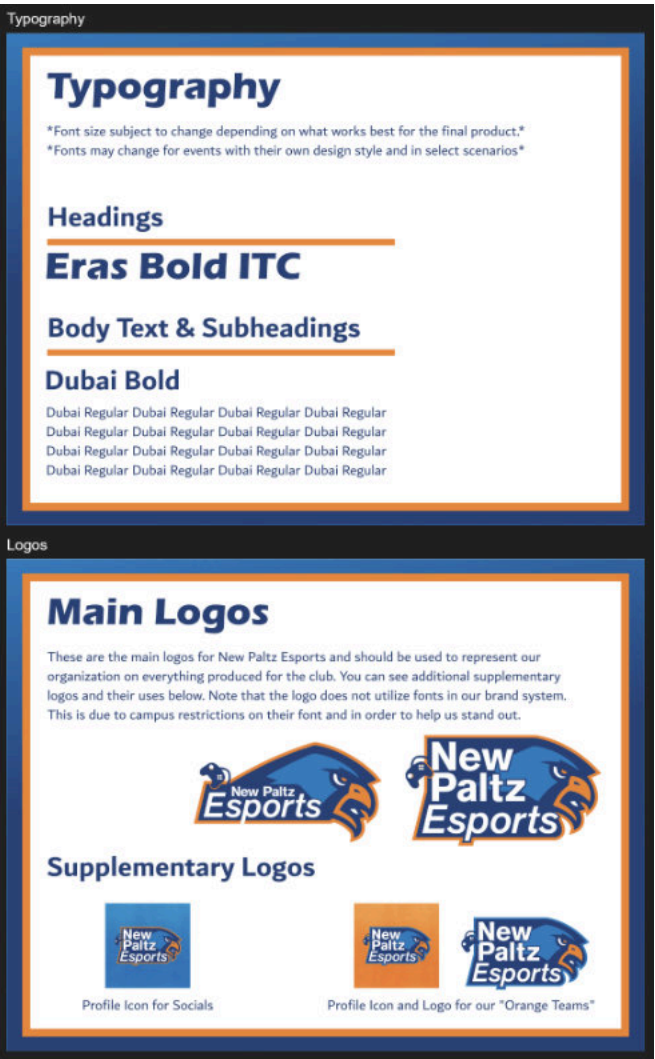
Case Study 2 - Collegiate Design

For this Cellegiate Design case study I held an interview with the director of Esports at UAlbany in order to see how their program handles design and referenced their school's work. From there I made iterations on a new logo for New Paltz Esports in order to apply what I learned. For my final outcome I renewed New Paltz Esports' branding and created brand guidelines for them!

In-Progress



Final Outcomes



Case Study 3 - 3D Compositing

For this final case study I discuss the application of 3D techniques in designing for Esports. I made two graphics using 3D character models and rendering techniques I developed through this case study. From there I put together the final works! You can see the time lapse for one of these on the website as well!

In-Progress



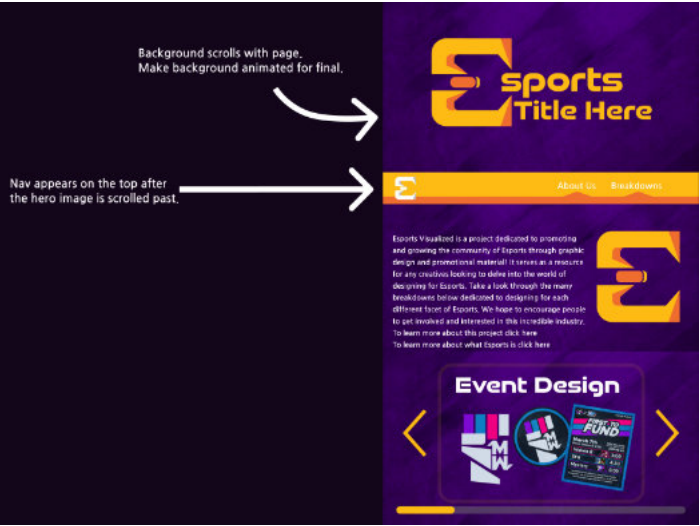
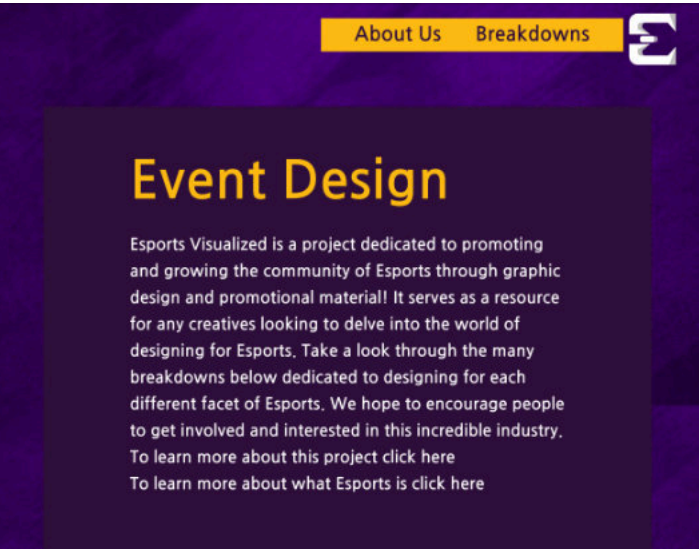
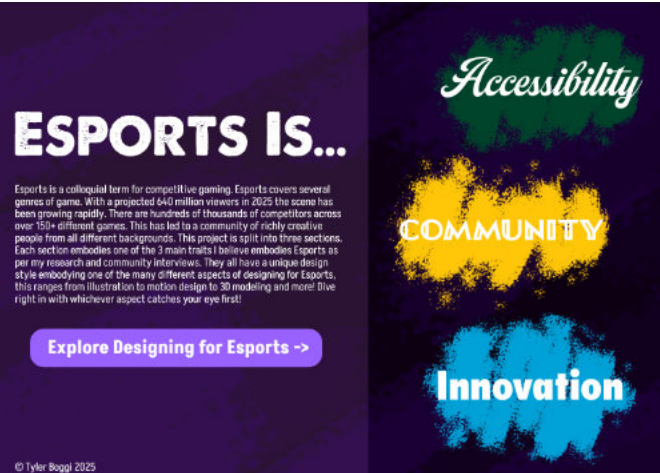
Final Outcomes



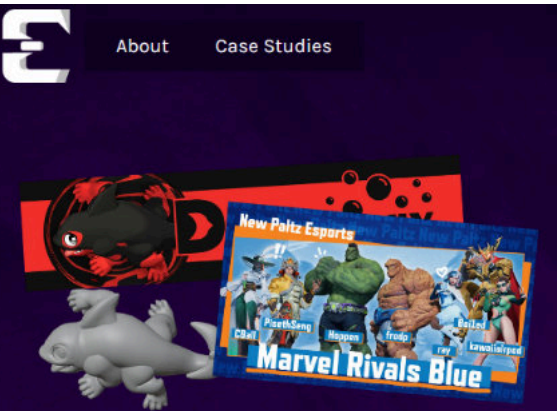
Esports Visualized Website

For my main deliverable for the project I made a website to document all of my case studies. I used Figma to do a rough mapping of the original concept and used HTML/CSS along with Javascript and Astro to fully code the final website!

In-Progress



Final Outcomes



3D Compositing

For this project I took on two 3D based assignments, the first one I'd like to talk about is a twitch banner I did for a Twitch streamer named Drewsephix. When talking about the use of 3D in Esports, oftentimes it comes down to the fact that in Esports players are frequently represented by the character that they play in their respective games. As such, a lot of graphics focusing on these players also implement the character they play in some way. The most organic-looking way to do this is through what is called 3D rigging and 3D compositing. 3D rigging involves taking the model of a character and its "skeleton", which is what animators use to pose a 3D model, and posing it in a way that translates well for the graphic. 3D compositing is using the engine's lighting and texture tools to produce a final render that matches or mimics the lighting and coloring of the design it is being used for.



Design Show 26 Showcase!

Here is what I showed at the Design Show! I had two posters, one as a general project poster and another as a QR code to get to the website. I hung my banner over top of me to attract more people to see the project. I also made stickers for both logos of my project and pins to give out to anyone who came up to my table. The main part of my table was using my monitor to showcase the website and having my laptop on my side of the table in order to see where they were looking and help guide them through the site.

In terms of feedback that I recieved, a lot of my work was already final so people were more focused on the concept of the project itself. People were very positive about the idea of the project but it still occasionally struggled to pull people who didnt know what it was into the project. That being said most people I talked to were able to get engaged so it may have just been people that wouldnt have been interested in the subject no matter what.



Obstacles

In terms of obstacles for this project there's one main one that I think of. When talking about and making work for this project the main issue was the general unfamiliarity with the concept of Esports. As mentioned earlier I received feedback to change my logo to more prominently include "Esports" in the title, and a lot of stereotypical video game symbolism was sort of forced into the project as a result of this unfamiliarity. This alone is not a bad thing, it changed how I made and presented my work of course. But it had a more important obstacle to me. I was already nervous in general when talking about my more niche interests and this was definitely a large hurdle to overcome especially with the unfamiliarity with my topic. Causing me to constantly detail what my project is actually about and force me to go through something I was very self-conscious about was difficult and forced me to confront how confident I was in my project very often.

My other main obstacle for this project was the constant working with other, what were essentially, clients. I was often forced to constantly multitask between working on my branding/website and working with my clients on the actual case study work, especially with this being on top of my work for the design show. I'm proud to be able to have overcome these obstacles and come out with a project I'm proud of!



Reflection

I am overall very happy with how the project turned out. I think I got more people to see what Esports is and what designing for Esports looks like through this project. On top of that I also got to work with people to create work that I am very proud of and taught me several things that I can take into my future as a designer. As for the state of the project itself, I don't see myself making any changes or getting involved with the project in the future. I feel like I did what I wanted to do and if I'm able to design for Esports in the future then it's gonna be as myself rather than under the alias of this project. That being said again I am very happy with the final product, especially the website. Most of the things I'd change looking back are small design changes, the only thing I wish I did differently was find a way to frame the project as a design firm for Esports in its branding while not sacrificing its approachability to a new audience. That was a problem I could never crack in my time with the project. I'm proud that I was able to stick with what I wanted to make and was able to more confidently and openly discuss it by the end of the project. Through this project I gained skills in public speaking, pitching ideas, branding, web design, 3d software, and more! Through this project I was able to reinforce skills that I aim to take with me in my preprofessional career and I could not be more proud of myself for sticking through it!



